

music from an early age. At first, his father let him pursue his interest only reluctantly, but later became more supportive, arranging music lessons for his son when the family acquired a piano.

After attending the Boston Latin School—an institution that prided itself on providing a classical education to Boston’s elite—Bernstein studied music at Harvard University, graduating in 1939. He studied under several distinguished academics and composers, but perhaps the most significant influence was Aaron Copland, who became a lifelong friend and mentor. After Harvard, Bernstein spent a year at the Curtis Institute of Music in Philadelphia, before settling in New York in 1940. Later that year he started his studies in conducting with Serge Koussevitzky at Tanglewood, the summer school of the Boston Symphony Orchestra.

Suffering from asthma, Bernstein was excused military service during World War II, leaving him free to compose and conduct. In 1943, he was appointed assistant conductor of the New York Philharmonic ([see box](#)), and two years later became music director of the newly formed New York City Symphony. He was also beginning to make his name as a composer, both of “serious” concert music and of a string of successful Broadway musicals.

Married life

As his reputation as a conductor grew, Bernstein worried that his private life might damage his chances of taking one of the top conducting jobs. He was homosexual at a time when it was a criminal offense in many places, and certainly not something to